unified engineering workbench: report

pass science works r&d internship 2026–27 · common technical assignment · candidate id: _____ · windows 11 x64 · c++17 backend, local web ui · tested on intel core i5-1240P, 15.7 GiB

1. design choices

- **one exe, browser ui.** `Launch.exe` is a statically linked c++17 program. it starts a small http server on `127.0.0.1` (random free port), then opens the default browser. there is no install, no runtime to ship (only windows system dlls, checked with `objdump -p`), nothing from the internet, and it is never reachable from the network.
- **strict layering.** `src/core` holds every engineering module (fea, batch/threads, stl, csv, hardware, backprop) and knows nothing about http. `src/server` is transport only: request parsing, routing, validation, background jobs. `src/frontend` only draws. every number on screen is computed in c++.
- **no third-party libraries.** a hand-written webgl viewer and canvas plots keep licensing trivial and the zip small (≈ 4 MB exe). the cost is less polish than a full 3d library; the benefit is that every line can be explained in a review.
- **interactive, not form-and-submit.** the fea re-solves every mesh while a slider moves (a synchronous route, ~10 ms per update); benchmark runs stream into a live chart; telemetry streams with sparklines; the backprop graph can be scrubbed through all 101 steps. an overview page maps every bullet of this brief to the place in the app that satisfies it.
- **responsive under load.** each http request has its own thread; long work (huge fea meshes, benchmarks) runs as a job with progress and cancel. a job publishes its result in one step only when it finishes, so cancelling never leaves half-written results.
- **actionable errors.** parsers report *what* is wrong, the *line*, and a *hint* on how to fix the file (e.g. “this is a binary stl: re-export with ‘ascii’ selected”). the ui validates inputs before sending; the backend validates again.

2. thermal fea (task c)

formulation

strong form $-d/dx(kA\,dT/dx) = qA$ on $0 < x < L$, $T(0) = 100$ °C, $T(L) = 20$ °C, with $L = 1$ m, $A = 1\text{e-}4$ m², $k = 10$ W/(m·K), $q = 10^4$ W/m³. lateral surfaces insulated, properties constant, steady state.

weak form with linear shape functions $N_1 = 1 - \xi$, $N_2 = \xi$ on an element of length h gives

$$\mathbf{k}_e = (kA/h)\cdot[1\ -1;\ -1\ 1]\ \text{(W/K)}, \quad \mathbf{f}_e = (qAh/2)\cdot[1\ 1]\ \text{(W)}$$

summed into a tridiagonal global system. both ends are dirichlet: the known column is moved to the right-hand side and the row is replaced by the identity, which keeps the matrix symmetric. the system is solved with the thomas algorithm (o(N)).

units: si throughout; temperatures in °C (only differences enter the equation, so °C vs K is safe).

verification against $T_{exact}(x) = 100 - 80x/L + (q/2k)\,x(L - x)$

N	h (m)	max midpoint error (°C)	$q\,h^2/(8k)$	max nodal error (°C)	order
10	0.1	1.25000000	1.25	5.7e-14	–
20	0.05	0.31250000	0.3125	2.6e-13	2.0000
40	0.025	0.07812500	0.078125	7.7e-13	2.0000
80	0.0125	0.01953125	0.01953125	1.1e-12	2.0000

the midpoint error uses **fe interpolation** $(T_i + T_{i+1})/2$, not the exact value at nodes. it equals the interpolation-error bound $h^2/8\cdot|T''| = qh^2/(8k)$ to 1e-9 and falls 4× per halving: second order. the peak temperature is 188.2 °C at x = 0.42 m.

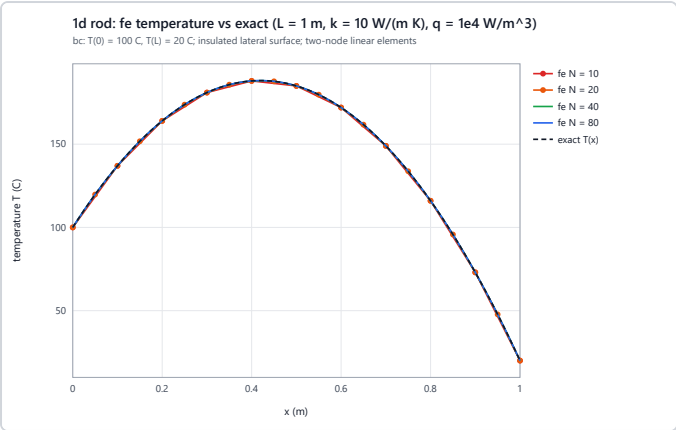


fig 1. fe solutions for N = 10–80 vs exact (raw data: results/fea_solution_nodes.csv)

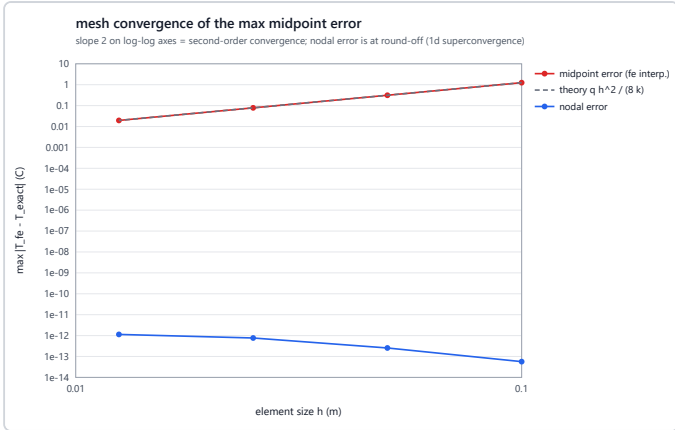


fig 2. log-log convergence; nodal error stays at round-off (results/fea_convergence.csv, fea_midpoints.csv)

debugging insight / what i learned. the first run showed nodal errors of ~1e-13 °C for every mesh, which looks like "nothing converges". it is a known 1d property: with linear elements and exact load integration the fe solution is exact *at the nodes* (the green's function of this operator is piecewise linear), so all discretisation error sits between nodes. reporting only nodal error would hide it, which is why the brief asks for midpoint values. tests now pin both facts: nodal error < 1e-9 and midpoint error = $qh^2/8k$. tests also check that interior rows of the assembled matrix sum to zero (a uniform temperature conducts no heat) and that the load vector sums to qAL = 1 W. a sign or scaling slip in assembly breaks one of these immediately.

3. multicore performance (task d)

setup	
cpu	intel core i5-1240P (hybrid: 4 performance + 8 efficiency cores)
cores	12 physical / 16 logical
ram	15.7 GiB
compiler	gcc 16.2.0 (winlibs mingw-w64 ucrt)
flags	-O3 -DNDEBUG -std=c++17, static link
workload	400 independent rod solves × 20,000 elements; seed 20261101; k ∈ [1, 400] W/(m·K), q ∈ [1e3, 1e5] W/m³
protocol	1 warm-up + 5 measured runs per config, median; configs interleaved each round
timed	solve loop only; case generation, thread start-up, file i/o and rendering excluded

implementation. `WorkerPool` is a fixed set of `std::thread`s created once (outside the timer). a batch is handed out one case at a time through an atomic counter (dynamic scheduling). each worker writes only into its own pre-allocated output slot, so results stay in input order without locks. the serial path is a plain loop over the same `fea::solve`.

agreement. the first run of every configuration is compared node by node with the serial output: max |ΔT| = 0 °C in every session (limit 1e-8). each case is computed by identical code on one thread, so results are bit-identical.

launch-to-ready (process creation → listening socket, `--ready-check`, 5 runs): 54, 58, 61, 62, 68 ms. browser start-up comes on top.

session	serial median (s)	p=1: median / speedup	p=2: median / speedup / eff.	p=4: median / speedup / eff.	notes
2	0.5585	0.5458 / 1.02	0.2922 / 1.91 / 0.96	0.1511 / 3.70 / 0.92	idle machine
3	0.5401	0.5396 / 1.00	0.2904 / 1.86 / 0.93	0.1475 / 3.66 / 0.92	idle machine
1	0.6800	0.7573 / 0.90	0.2920 / 2.33 / 1.16	0.1428 / 4.76 / 1.19	browser + backend active; serial reps 0.41–0.93 s

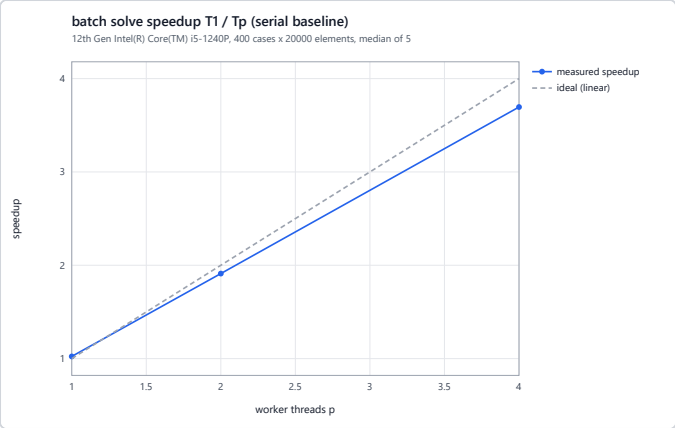


fig 3. speedup T_1/T_p, session 2 (raw reps: results/benchmark_session*/benchmark_raw.csv)

analysis

- **scaling.** on an idle machine, p = 2 gives 1.86–1.91× and p = 4 gives 3.66–3.70× (efficiency ≈ 0.92). losses come from memory bandwidth (each solve streams ~1 MB of vectors), allocator traffic (every solve allocates its own vectors) and a short tail where the last cases finish on fewer threads.
- **noise source found and fixed.** the first harness ran configs as blocks; the 1-thread pool then looked ~1.5× slower than serial. a probe running the same loop on a fresh thread showed no thread penalty. alternating serial and pool(1) gave a ratio ≈ 1.0, and both slowed from ~0.40 s to ~0.60 s after a few seconds: the laptop's turbo budget expires. block order gave the first config the fast clock, so configs are now interleaved (probes kept in `tools/experiments`).
- **session 1 is kept, not hidden.** its "superlinear" 4.76× is not real scaling: its serial median was inflated by clock and core-type changes while other apps ran (single-thread reps spread 2.3×). treat speedups as ±5 % on this hardware.
- **limits.** one laptop; no affinity pinning; a single-logical-cpu machine would still run the parallel path (tested), but its speedup cannot be assessed.

4. cad / ansys data (task b)

ascii stl and **nodal csv** (`node_id,x_m,y_m,z_m,temperature_C`) are parsed and validated in c++. the ui overlays both in one 3d scene (rotate, pan, zoom, fit, view presets, opacity, wireframe) with the nodes coloured by temperature (inferno, viridis or cool–warm), a legend in °C, an adjustable colour range and threshold, hover tooltips and click-to-pin inspection (node id, x/y/z in m, T in °C). examples are self-created; the csv is labelled synthetic in the file name, the provenance file and the ui. rejected inputs (each with a line number and hint): empty or whitespace-only, binary stl (even with a "solid" header), wrong vertex count, nan/inf, truncated, wrong or extra columns, duplicate ids, T < −273.15 °C, header-only. size limits: 256 MB, 2M triangles, 5M nodes.

tested input	size	backend parse	full ui path
stl, 1.2M triangles	156 MB	1.1 s	114 MB file: 4.9 s to rendered
stl, 2.16M triangles	282 MB	rejected: size limit	–
csv, 1M nodes / 4M nodes	42 / 171 MB	1.1–1.6 s / 6.4 s	33 MB, 1M nodes: 3.4 s; node pick instant

5. embedded integration (task e)

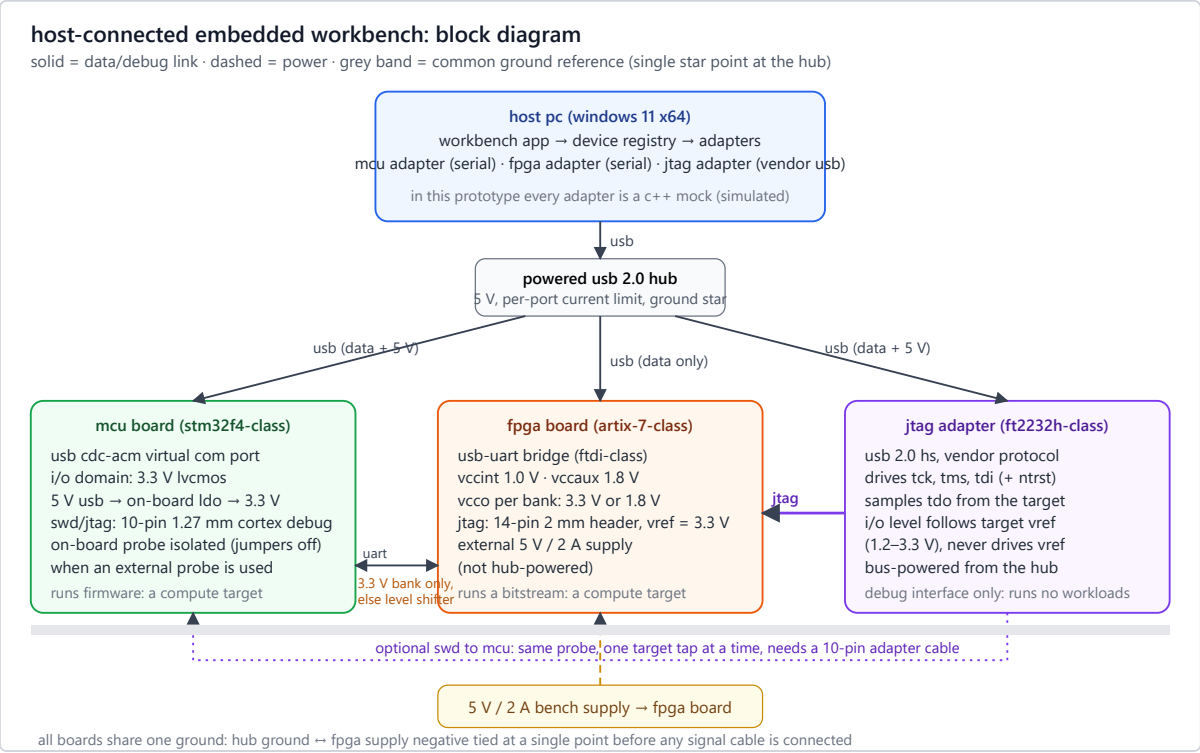


fig 4. block diagram (full pin/voltage table with connectors and pin assumptions: docs/embedded_design.md)

link	voltage / level	notes
usb → mcu board	5 V in, 3.3 V i/o	cdc-acm com port, bus-powered
usb → fpga uart	3.3 V bank	data only; board on own 5 V/2 A supply
jtag → fpga	follows target vref	adapter drives tck/tms/tdi, target drives tdo; one master per chain
swd → mcu (opt.)	3.3 V vtref	on-board st-link jumpers off
mcu ↔ fpga uart	3.3 ↔ vcco	level translator if the bank is 1.8 V
ground	single star point	connected before any signal cable

jtag is a debug interface, not a compute board: it executes no user workload; it bridges usb to a target's test access port, its i/o voltage follows the target's vref, and it speaks a different protocol from the uart boards. the c++ mocks share one `DeviceAdapter` interface (discovery, capabilities, connect/disconnect, telemetry). but only the mcu and fpga report `can_run_workloads = true`, and every reply and ui card is labelled **simulated**. **recoverable failure:** injecting `timeout_once` makes the next operation wait 400 ms, return `timeout, recoverable` and fault the link. telemetry is refused until a reconnect, which succeeds. integration plan (8 steps: schematics → one board at a time → ground first → read-only software → jtag with target powered → link last → timeouts → reverse disconnect) and limitations are in `docs/embedded_design.md`.

6. backpropagation (task f)

param	∂J/∂θ analytic	central diff. (ε = 1e-6)	|err|	after step
w	−1.2094644752	−1.2094644751	1.1e-10	0.6209464475
b	−1.2094644752	−1.2094644751	1.1e-10	0.1209464475
v	−0.7106820475	−0.7106820474	5.3e-11	1.0710682047
c	−1.5378828427	−1.5378828426	1.1e-10	0.1537882843

forward: z = 0.5, h = ŷ = 0.4621171573, J = 1.1825418190 → 0.6857737650 after the handwritten update. all gradients are negative because ŷ < y and each parameter raises ŷ, so descent increases all four. the c++ code uses the hand-derived chain rule (no autodiff); values match an independent python computation to 1e-14.

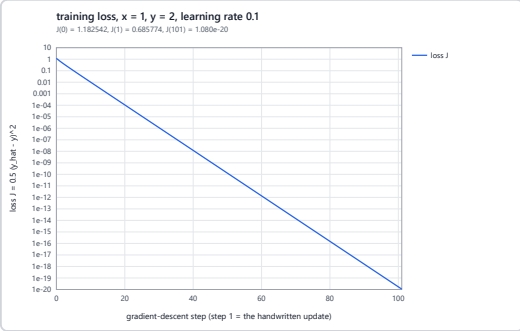


fig 5. loss over 101 steps, log axis (results/backprop_loss.csv). it falls monotonically and roughly geometrically to ~1e-20: one sample can be fit exactly, and near the optimum the loss is locally quadratic.

7. tests

78 / 78 pass (`ctest` , output in `docs/test_output.txt`), and the release build compiles with **zero warnings** under `-Wall -Wextra -Wpedantic` : fea 11 (assembly invariants, bcs, exact nodes, midpoint = $qh^2/8k$, order 2, peak location, invalid inputs), mesh study 7 (exact peak, error arches vanish at nodes, csv row counts, limits, cancel), batch/threads 11 (seed reproducibility, ranges, serial = parallel for 1/2/3/4/7 workers, input order, cancel, pool reuse after exceptions, worker capping, interleaved run order, single-cpu path), stl 12 and csv 8 (valid, crlf/bom/uppercase, every rejection class, limits, fixture files), hardware 8 (discovery, jtag not a compute target, state machine, deterministic telemetry, timeout and recovery), backprop 6 (reference values, gradient check, wrong-derivative challenge, update, monotone loss), transport/api 15 (url and header parsing, path traversal blocked, 400/404/409/422 with hints, binary payload layout, stl unit conversion, live and exported fea, job export, cancelled jobs publish nothing, hardware recovery over http, evidence flags only for files that exist). every view was also exercised by hand in a browser (sliders, hover, zoom, streaming, fault injection) at desktop and 375 px widths, and `docs/walkthrough` holds 14 timestamped frames captured in real time from the running app (validation, a job's progress and cancel, a benchmark mid-run, timeout recovery, rejected files) with the backend log.

8. limitations

- physics: 1d, steady, constant k, uniform q, dirichlet ends only.
- stl ascii only, no repair; the stl unit is converted to metres in c++, but there is no mesh-to-result registration. csv: one fixed schema; ansys text exports need renaming (documented, not tested against a live ansys install).
- performance measured on a single hybrid-core laptop with turbo; ±5 % between sessions.
- hardware is simulated end to end; pinouts are assumptions until checked against real schematics.
- local single-user http server (no auth, loopback only); unsigned exe may trigger a smartscreen “run anyway”.
- ai assistance was used extensively and is disclosed in `docs/ai_use_log.md` with every error it made.